

Flock cameras raise privacy concerns

Trinity Polk, KTEN News

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(KTEN) — You may have seen one of these on a post with a solar panel along a street or highway near you.

The roadside cameras capture images of vehicles and license plates, giving law enforcement another tool when they're looking for a vehicle linked to a crime.

"They're used for the purposes of warrant recovery, stolen vehicles, stolen property, missing persons, kidnapping, human trafficking, drug enforcement," said Atoka County Sheriff Kody Simpson.

But not every camera or license plate reader is Flock; Flock Safety is just one company that makes them.

And Simpson says some of the concerns start with misconceptions about what these high-tech devices can actually do.

"They do not have facial recognition; we see a full picture of the rear of the vehicle, sometimes the front tag, and a close-up of the tag," the sheriff said.

The cameras are not used in Atoka County to write traffic tickets, and a plate "hit" doesn't tell deputies who is driving.

"They're very visible. We're not hiding them. We're not trying to hide them. That's not what our goal is," Simpson said.

The sheriff also believes that visibility is helping deter crime, telling us the county is seeing less theft and fewer stolen vehicles coming through.

But the debate centers on the data these cameras *do* collect: Who can search that information; why it is collected; how long the data is retained; and the potential for misuse

"I know there's been a lot of exposure of bad cops that have misused this," Simpson said. "I can tell you that there's nothing a good cop hates worse than a bad cop, and this has exposed a lot of bad cops."

The sheriff adds that Atoka County requires a crime to be tied to a search of the database, and there are plans to reduce how long its Flock data is retained from 30 days to seven.

Just months ago, Atoka County used Flock hits to help locate a five-year-old girl who was kidnapped from Texas.

"We were able to utilize Flock and Flock hits on her, and effected arrest on her and rescued the little girl," Simpson said. "She was able to go back to her guardians."

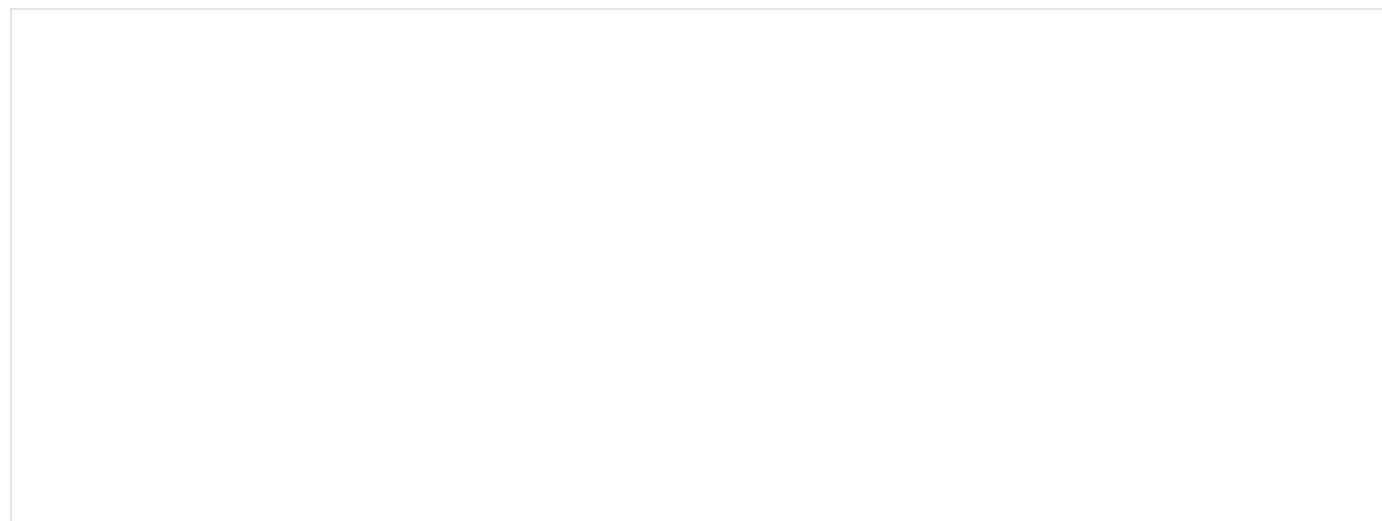
Other Texoma cities are weighing the use of the same technology.

In Ardmore, commissioners voted 4-1 this week to renew the city's Flock contract despite pushback from some residents over privacy concerns.

Five Flock cameras have been temporarily installed at major entrances in Marietta since early July.

The Marietta City Council is set to discuss the future use of that technology on Thursday.

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Trinity Polk

reporter/producer